Harriet Tubman Visits a Therapist

By Carolyn Gage

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Harriet Tubman, suspected of planning an escape on the Underground Railroad, has been sent to the Therapist for an evaluation.*
ACTRESS 2: *The Therapist, another African American woman, warns Harriet about the dangers of radical action*
ACTRESS 1: *Two women who share the same oppression, but whose definitions of survival are in direct conflict . . .*
TOGETHER: *Harriet Tubman Visits a Therapist by Carolyn Gage*

(At Rise: The THERAPIST is reviewing HARRIET's file. She is a ligh-tskinned African American woman who wears the clothing of a contemporary middle-class therapist. There is a soft knock on the door.)

THERAPIST: Come in. *(There is another knock, and she crosses to the door and opens it. HARRIET TUBMAN stands in the doorway. HARRIET's speech and movements are deliberately slow and dull at first. She stands waiting for orders, head bowed.)* Come in. Harriet Tubman? You're right on time. *(She gestures into the room. HARRIET lifts her eyes briefly. Her face is expressionless. There is a long silence. The THERAPIST sighs and smiles at HARRIET.)* Harriet, do you know why you're here?

HARRIET: Massuh Edward done sent me.

THERAPIST: Do you know why?

HARRIET: Cain't sell no nigga like me.

THERAPIST: I don't think that's why. *(HARRIET looks down.)* I understand why you feel that way. That's a very natural conclusion for a slave to draw. But in this case, I think Mr. Brodas is genuinely concerned about you. I think Mr. Brodas likes you. He speaks about you with a great deal of

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pride. He's allowed you to choose your own husband, and John Tubman is a free man. That's a very unusual thing for a slaveowner to do. And he lets you hire out to a shipbuilder-

HARRIET: He take alluh money.

THERAPIST: Well, that's not exactly true. I understand that you get to keep what you make over what you owe him. *(HARRIET snorts.)* I understand you've been able to buy yourself a pair of oxen. That's pretty impressive. You could even buy your freedom someday.

HARRIET: Time I'ze daid.

THERAPIST: *(The THERAPIST studies HARRIET for a moment.)* You know I share your feelings about slavery. All day long I listen to women tell me stories that make me sick. Stories of rape- raping children, of beating- beating pregnant women, stories of murder, or torture, of live burnings, of babies being sold away from their mothers, of chain gangs ... *(HARRIET looks away.)* But I'm not going to change it, and neither are you. We can drive ourselves crazy thinking about it. We can kill ourselves fighting it. Or we can make the most of what is possible.

HARRIET: *(Eyes down.)* Nat Turner. *(Looking at the THERAPIST for the first time as she speaks. HARRIET drops the dull-witted act.)* Nat Turner. He killed fifty-- seven whitefolks.

THERAPIST: *(Taken aback by HARRIET5 intensity.)* They hanged Nat Turner.

HARRIET: *(Looking at her hands, acting again.)* Hanged a man las' week over to Bucktown for stealin' chickens.

THERAPIST: *(Losing her temper.)* Nat Turner is the reason you can't read. Did you know that? After his uprising, they made it illegal to teach slaves to read or write. After Nat Turner, we couldn't even meet to go to

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church, unless a white man was the preacher. After Nat Turner, they wouldn't let us talk to each other in the fields, but they wouldn't let us just work either. Oh, no. After Nat Turner, we all had to sing while we worked-oh, except of course, "Go Down, Moses." Now, thanks to Nat Turner, you can die for singing that song.

HARRIET: *(Singing.)* GO DOWN, MOSES, / WAY DOWN IN EGYPT'S LAND . . .

THERAPIST: You think I'm an Uncle Tom, don't you? You think I sold out.

HARRIET: *(Continues singing. Closing her eyes, she raises her voice.)* TELL OLE PHARAOH, LET MY PEOPLE GO . . . *(HARRIET looks at the THERAPIST, who is silent now.)* Didn't hab no gun. Prophet Turner. A sword. Can you see dat? Had hissef a sword! *(She laughs.)* What he gonna do wid a sword? Slit open de sow's belly?

THERAPIST: Are you thinking of killing someone? *(HARRIET looks at her hands. – no response)* I'm going to be frank with you. Mr. Brodas has sent you to me, because he's afraid you're going to run away.

HARRIET: *(Bursts out laughing.)* Oh, he skeered! He tell you dat Harriet bin lookin' mighty greazy. Gonna slip herself th'oo de massuh's han's. *(She laughs again.)*

THERAPIST: *(Smiling along with the joke.)* Your husband seems to think you've been "lookin' mighty greazy," too.

HARRIET: *(She stops laughing.)* John say dat? He tell you dat?

THERAPIST: He told Mr. Brodas. *(HARRIET is stunned.)* Harriet, nobody's against you here. Your husband loves you and Mr. Brodas has a great deal of respect for you. But, if you run away, neither one of them is going to be able to save you from the slave catchers-or their dogs. You've got too much to live for to throw your life away like that.

HARRIET: John bin talkin' to Massuh Edward?

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THERAPIST: Harriet, I want to help you. You are in a very serious situation. Mr. Brodas has asked me to determine whether or not I think you're going to run. *(HARRIET looks at her.)* I'm going to tell him that I'd like to see you for a few more visits, but after that, unless there's a change in your attitude, I will have to tell him the truth. I doubt he'll let you hire out after that. *(HARRIET says nothing).* You're so busy dreaming about a world you don't have, you're missing out on the one right here. Learn to focus on the things you *can* change, learn to appreciate what you have right now. Little by little, one day at a time, your life will get better. *(HARRIET says nothing.)* I knew a woman once who decided to run. One night, she took her two daughters - - one was six and the other twelve-and she ran. *(HARRIET is keenly interested)* They caught her, of course, as they catch most runaways.

HARRIET: How far she git?

THERAPIST: To the Delaware border. (*HARRIET nods. The THERAPIST narrates the rest if her story with clinical detachment.)* It was the hounds that got her. By the time they called off the dogs, her daughter-the six-year-old-was already dead. And then they took turns raping the twelve-year-old while they made the mother watch. After that, she wouldn't have anything to do with the child. She wouldn't touch her, wouldn't talk to her. She treated her like she didn't exist. Right up until the girl was sold down South. *(HARRIET says nothing.)* Do you think this woman made a wise decision?

HARRIET: She didn't hab no gun?

THERAPIST: What if she did? She was outnumbered. Or do you think she should have shot her daughters?

HARRIET: *(Shrugging.)* Lib in de no'th or die in de South.

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THERAPIST: You would shoot your own children?

HARRIET: I seen mah sistuhs-Linah and Soph-seen 'em sol' off on de chain gang, an' dat day I wisht dey wuz daid, an' I bin prayin' dey was daid ev'y day aftuh dat, too. Ain't no livin' when dey kin do yo' body any way dey like.

THERAPIST: *(Vehement.)* Oh, yes, there is! We are so much more than our physical bodies-

HARRIET: *(Cutting her off)* Look! Now, you look! *(She pulls her shirt out and pulls up the back.)* Heah-you look at dat. You look at what de white man done.

THERAPIST: *(Turning away.)* I've seen plenty of scars.

HARRIET: No, you look, cuz you ain't seen dis 'oman's scars. You therapizin' on me, you look. You stan' up heah, an' you look. *(The THERAPIST looks.)* You see dat? Dat is a fiel' o' flesh been ploughed by de debil's own han'.

THERAPIST: But you *don't* have to let it scar your soul.

HARRIET: What you talkin' 'bout? Mah soul? Dis heah is mah soul! Dis black Ashanti skin is mah soul! *(She turns to face the THERAPIST.)*

THERAPIST: *(Becoming very clinical.)* And what does it do for you to keep remembering?

HARRIET: *(HARRIET starts to respond with anger, but she stops herself. A smile spreads slowly over her face.)* You is sleepin' wid de massuh.

THERAPIST: *(Hesitating, she chooses her words carefully.)* Sometimes Mr. Brodas visits with me. *(HARRIET is still smiling.)* That doesn't affect my belief that your running away would be suicidal. And it doesn't affect the fact that I want to help you.

HARRIET: *(Mumbling.- lowers her eyes)* No'm.

THERAPIST: You don't have to put on an act for me. *(HARRIET looks up, puzzled.)* I

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know what you're doing. *(Silence.)* You don't have to please me. *(Starting over.)* I sleep with Mr. Brodas ... *(Hesitating.)* He's a kind man.

HARRIET: Oh, yas'm, dat he is. He be de bes' massuh in de world! Dat's des what I allus say, dat Massuh Edward, he-

THERAPIST: *(Cutting her off)* I hate him . . . I hate him, because he's white, because he's a slaveowner, because he's a drunkard, because he's a coward and a liar, I hate him because he uses women, I hate him because he doesn't bother to wash when he comes to me. I hate him so much, believe it or not, he doesn't bother me. I hate him so much, I don't let him have anything.

HARRIET: He got yo' body.

THERAPIST: I'm not in it. *(HARRIET says nothing.)* I haven't been in it since I was twelve and I watched the dogs tear my little sister to pieces. I had already left my body before the first white man climbed on top of me. And I wasn't in my body when they raped my mother. I wasn't in my body when they sold me down South. And I wasn't in my body when I had a white man's baby at thirteen. I wasn't in my body when they sold her five years later. And I wasn't in my body when Mr. Brodas made his proposition. I keep myself alive . . .

HARRIET: While you is larnin' de other women to be de slaves.

THERAPIST: I teach them how to survive. I have helped women, Harriet. Maybe not you. But I have helped women. *(She pauses. HARRIET says nothing.*)You think this is bullshit. *(HARRIET says nothing.)* How many women could live day to day with your level of rage? You don't have children. What do you think that anger would do to a child? And how long do you think you're going to be able to live like this? Oh, you can make a run for it, all right. But Pennsylvania is a long way off. Do you really

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think you're going to have the stamina to make it? It takes a cool head to go the distance, and I can tell you right now, Harriet Tubman, you don't have it. Your rage will get you over the county line, maybe. But the Delaware border? Unh-unh. Never.

HARRIET: *(The THERAPIST has hit a nerve, and HARRIET reconsiders.)* You bin up no'th.

THERAPIST: I was captured.

HARRIET: You bin to Delaware.

THERAPIST: To the border.

HARRIET: Draw me dat map.

THERAPIST: I can't do that. *(HARRIET looks at her.)* I don't encourage my clients to take reckless chances with their lives.

HARRIET: *(Angry)* I got two rights-de right to freedom and de right to die.

THERAPIST: *(The THERAPIST rises.)* I have the right to live.

HARRIET: Libbin'! What you talkin', 'oman? You ain't eben inside yo' own skin! *(HARRIET, enraged, turns to go. She opens the door, but is seized by a fit of narcolepsy. The THERAPIST watches HARRIET for a moment, and then closes the door.)*

THERAPIST: You want the map? All right, Harriet Tubman, I'll give you the map ... Harriet, listen to me. We don't have very much time, and I want you to listen and remember. You are standing in the middle of a field. It's the field behind the Brodas plantation. It's nighttime, Harriet, and you are alone. You are leaving tonight. John is asleep in the cabin. Can you see the cabin where John Tubman is sleeping? *(Slowly, HARRIET nods.)* It's a clear night and the stars are out. Look up, and see if you can see one star that's brighter than the others -- that's the North Star. You're going to keep that in front of this shoulder. *(gestures to*

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Harriet's shoulder) You stay on the edge of the swamp, Harriet. And now the swamp is opening up, widening. And you're over the Choptank River. Follow the Choptank, Harriet, about seventy miles on the Choptank River. *(HARRIET nods.)* You're very close to the Delaware border now. There's a farm on the other side of the border, the Cowgill farm in Willow Grove, and that's all you need to know, because once you get to the Cowgill farm, they'll take care of you the rest of the way into Pennsylvania. All you have to do is get to the farm. You understand? *(HARRIET nods.)* And now, I'm going to count backwards from five-

HARRIET: *(Breaking through with great effort, but still in a trance.)* I see dem! I see dem! De women wid de lights. I see dem in de trees aroun' me. I see dem stretchin' out they han's to me. Dey is callin' my name, an' I am reachin' out my han's to dem -

THERAPIST: There aren't any women with you. You are alone.

HARRIET: No, dat I ain't. Dey is shinin' wid glory, dese black women, an' dey is gonna pull me up offa dat groun', gonna snatch me right 'way fum de han's of de whiteman. Doan matter I forget de way doan matter, 'cuz dese women, dey been heah befo' and dey gonna bring me on acrost. Dey is shinin' an' laughin' an' dey is takin' me by de han' to freedom.

THERAPIST: Harriet, these women don't exist.

HARRIET: Oh, yes, dey do. Dese is de women dat lib so good dey cain't die. Dese is de women fum Africa, de women who pitch deysefs off de ship, rather die dan lib in de chains ob slavery. Dese is de women who kilt dey own chilrun 'fo' dey see dem sol' on de auction block . . . de women who kilt dey massuhs wid dey bare han's, de women dey cain't skeer no mo' cause dey already done do de wors' an' dey still alibe.

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Dese is de African women, de Ashanti women. *(Smiling in her trance, HARRIET begins to sing, and the THERAPIST talks, over her singing.)* GO DOWN, MOSES / WAY DOWN IN EGYPT'S LAND / TELL OLE PHARAOH / LET MY PEOPLE GO.

THERAPIST: Harriet, I'm going to count backwards from five. And when I say "one," you will open your eyes. You will not remember any of this experience. Five ... four ... three ... two ... ONE. *(HARRIET opens her eyes, and the two women look at each other. The THERAPIST smiles.)* Harriet, I am going to have to recommend to Mr. Brodas that you be removed from your present position and put in the fields to work where there is closer supervision.

HARRIET: Put me in de prison-I'ze gone. All de chains in de wod' cain't keep me now. My freedom ain't in the han's of you or Massuh Edward or eben in mah own han's. *(The THERAPIST is busy writing. HARRIET crosses to the door, and looks back. She exits, leaving the THERAPIST standing. Blackout.)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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